

POLITICS IN INDIA: NATURE AND TRENDS

India being a multi-cultural and multi-ethnic nation has its unique share of characteristics which in turn influences the political, social, and economic scenario in India. The chief characteristic of politics is that its nature keeps on changing with the passage of time and situations and this is the position of the Indian politics. Before independence, the nature of the Indian politics was different, but lots of changes have taken place in its nature after independence. After evaluating its performance since independence, it can be known that so many new tendencies have emerged in it which has wildly influenced the nature of the Indian politics. India is a pluralistic society and the various groups, castes, religions, minorities and the people speaking various languages have influenced the Indian politics, as a result of which so many new trends have emerged in it and brief description of these is given below:

Nature And Trends of Indian Politics

The nature of Indian politics has been shaped by its social, economic, religious and geographical conditions and characterized by its democratic framework, federal structure, and a multi-party system. These special conditions have given a distinct shape to Indian politics, which is characterized by the following features:

- **GOVERNANCE AND ADMINISTRATION:** India is a Sovereign Socialist Secular Democratic Republic with a Parliamentary form of government which is federal in structure with unitary features. As the world's largest democracy, India operates under a parliamentary system influenced by the British Westminster model. The Constitution of India, adopted in 1950, lays the foundation for the political system, ensuring fundamental rights and freedoms for citizens. It establishes a federal structure, dividing powers between the central government and state governments, essential for accommodating the diverse needs of India's population. This division of powers is essential for accommodating the diverse needs of India's population, which exceeds 1.4 billion people. The Constitution also enshrines the principles of justice, liberty, equality, and fraternity, guiding the governance of the nation
- **MULTI- PARTY SYSTEM:** Indian politics is marked by a vibrant and diverse party system, with numerous political parties representing various ideologies, regional interests, and social groups. This resulted in a robust multi-party democracy. The two major national parties, the Indian National Congress (INC) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), coexist with numerous regional parties like the Trinamool Congress, DMK, and Shiv Sena, which hold significant sway in their respective states. This multi-party system reflects the country's vast cultural, linguistic, and religious diversity, making coalition politics a common feature. As per the latest publications dated 23rd March 2024 from Election Commission of India, and subsequent notifications, there are six national parties, fifty-eight state parties and 2,736 unrecognized parties.
- **ELECTORAL PROCESS:** Elections in India are conducted by the Election Commission, an independent body responsible for ensuring free and fair elections. The electoral process is a significant aspect of Indian democracy, with millions of citizens participating in local, state, and national elections. The right to vote empowers citizens to influence governance and hold elected representatives accountable, making it a cornerstone of democratic participation. There were 97,97,51,847 registered electors, marking a 7.43% increase from 91,19,50,734 in 2019. A total of 64.64 crore votes were cast, compared to 61.4 crore in 2019. Election Commission has often been maligned by some recognized political parties after losing elections in certain states. Hue and cry are raised about the unfairness in elections and demand of returning to ballot paper system for conducting elections.
- **CASTE AND IDENTITY POLITICS:** Indian politics is caste ridden politics. Caste is a very old and prominent basis of social stratification in India wherein some castes were given superior positions with social and economic privileges that were denied to the lower caste of people. As for example, recently that is in 2024, a Dalit man was allegedly thrashed by a brick kiln owner in Rajasthan for allegedly touching a water pot. In current Indian political fray, Political parties often align themselves with specific social groups, castes, and communities, leading to identity-based politics. This has resulted in the emergence of various political movements advocating for the rights of marginalized groups, including Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes. As for example in January 2025, Pro- Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange-Patil launched his seventh indefinite hunger strike in the last 16 months, renewing his demand for Marathi reservation under the Other Backward Classes (OBC) quota. While this has empowered many, it has also led to challenges such as caste-based violence and social tensions, complicating the political landscape. Since independence, political parties have leveraged caste dynamics to mobilize support. For instance, Dalit and Other Backward Class (OBC) communities have increasingly become politically active, with parties like the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) championing their rights. However, the emphasis on caste has also led to vote-bank politics, which sometimes undermines meritocracy and policy-driven governance. The caste has influenced the politics of India from top to bottom and thus given a distinct character to the Indian politics.
It is worth to mention here that the former President of India K.R. Narayanan has rightly mentioned that, "What is obstructing the unity and emotional integration of India is not so much the large divisions into regions, languages and religions, but the atomization of our society into numerous castes, sub-castes and tribes".
- **SWITCH FROM ONE PARTY DOMINANCE TO COALITION POLITICS AND VICE VERSA:** There was a time when the political scenario in India was described as the 'Congress Raj'. The term itself explained the fact that after independence the Indian National Congress was one single party that dominated the political scenario in India for a very long time. A look into the election statistics will reveal that the Congress party has been dominant at the national level with large majorities in the Parliament but at the state level only the first two decades after Independence belonged to it.

The elections of 1989 came to be as a turning point in the politics of India. In the elections of 1989, Congress faced a defeat but did not result in majority for any other party. This defeat of the Congress party marked the end of congress dominance over the Indian party system. The national front received support from two diametrically opposite parallel groups: the BJP and the Left Front. After 1989, no single party secured a clear majority of seats in any Lok Sabha election held since 1989 till 2014. This development initiated an era of coalition governments at the Centre, in which regional parties played a crucial role in forming ruling alliances but in 2014 and 2019 Lok Sabha election, the BJP got the clear majority on its own. But again, in the recent elections that is in the 18th Lok Sabha elections of 2024, BJP failed to secure the majority as it bagged only 240 seats out of the 543 seats. Therefore, BJP with the help of its alliances National democratic Alliances form the government and is currently governing the country.

- **CORRUPTION AND ACCOUNTABILITY:** Corruption remains a significant challenge in Indian politics, affecting public trust in political institutions. Various anti-corruption movements and campaigns, as for example the Delhi Liquor Scam of 2022, west Bengal teacher recruitment scam of 2024 and so on, have emerged over the years, highlighting the need for transparency and accountability in governance. The Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, aimed at establishing an ombudsman to address corruption, is one such initiative.
- **Media, Technology and Social Media Influence:** The role of media in Indian politics is pivotal, as it serves as a platform for public discourse and a watchdog for government actions. However, the media landscape is also fraught with challenges, including issues of press freedom and the influence of political parties on media narratives. There is no doubt that media plays a very important role in politics as it influences public opinion and helps define and take up the issues. It can keep the powerful in check by seeking transparency in their actions. Thus, an independent media is an effective check on government's power and influence over its citizens. The media should be fearless, unbiased and true saver of democracy. Instead, it has become the tool of serving the mighty, powerful politician as some media houses are owned by the business house which in order to fulfil their interest from the government alleged by critiques of becoming biased and focus intensively to promote the goodness of the party in power. However, press freedom has eroded rapidly in recent years, with India being ranked 161 out of 180 nations last year (2023), the lowest ever for the country. In 2024 index, its ranking improved by two places to 159. Thus, still in Indian media is doing various reporting on past and current issues which are very important for democracy. Social media has also emerged as a powerful tool for political mobilization and engagement, particularly among the youth. In the 2014, general elections, BJP used voice broadcasting, used cookies on party websites to track individual users and create customized advertisements and Congress Project Shakti.
- **RELIGION AND INDIAN POLITICS:** Religious faith is very old and strong in India which is apparent due to partition in 1947 on the religious line. Religion significantly influences Indian politics. The secular foundation of the Indian Constitution coexists with political mobilization along religious lines. The rise of Hindutva as a political ideology, championed by the BJP, has sparked debates about the balance between secularism and majoritarianism. Simultaneously, regional identities play a vital role, with states like Tamil Nadu, Punjab, and West Bengal often asserting their distinct cultural and political identities. This regionalism has fueled demands for greater autonomy and sometimes friction between the center and the states. Although the framers of the constitution provided a secular polity for India, yet the real secularism is still not visible at the societal level. Even in the post-independence period, many political parties formed like (Akali Dal in Punjab for Sikhs) on the religious line. The recently formed AIUDF (All India United Democratic Front) in Assam also uses religion to get the support of religious minorities and get elected the candidates from only minority dominated areas. These, along with some other elements arose the feeling of communalism. In India maximum communal riots occurred due to narrow minded political leaders to fulfill their narrow gains. However, over the years, the nature of communalism has changed whereas before 1970s the communal riots mainly confined between Hindus and Muslims. In the recent years the conflicts have been spread to the others like Hindus versus Sikhs, Hindu versus Tribal Groups too. Of late, the communalism has also been reinforced by religious fundamentalism. Communal riots emerged following the demolition of Babri Masjid, the riot in Bombay in 1993, killing more than five hundred people and Godhra incident of Gujarat in 2002.
- **IMPACT OF GLOBALISATION:** Globalization has further impacted Indian politics, influencing policy decisions and party platforms. Economic reforms have led to significant changes in the political landscape, with urban areas experiencing rapid development while rural regions often lag behind. This urban-rural divide has resulted in discontent and demands for more inclusive policies that address the needs of all citizens. Issues such as trade, investment, and labor rights are becoming central to political discourse, reflecting the interconnectedness of the global economy.
- **REGIONALISM:** It primarily implies love for one's own region rather than the love for one's own country. Though the tendency developed during the British period, it continues to play a very big role in free India. Today several political parties are found thriving in different parts of India mainly by exploiting the regional sentiments of the people. The political leaders encourages inter-state disputes and people were made to fight against each other in the name of language, culture etc. Thus, it can be said that regionalism has become an integral part of politics in India
- **ABSENCE OF IDEOLOGY:** A significant feature of our present day Indian politics is the growth of ideology less political parties. Each political party is supposed to have some political ideology of its own but that is not happening in India. There is mushroom growth of Political parties but these are not ideology based. India lacks such Political parties which have clear cut socio-economic and political programme to uplift the whole country, providing the electorate and alternative to choose. There are of course national level political parties with clear ideologies like Congress(I), BJP, CPI, CPI(M) etc but the number of ideology less parties are gradually increasing. For example in February, 2002, Bhartiya Janta Party and Bahujan Samaj Party contested

the assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh on separate manifestoes and during election propaganda they threw lot of mud on each other. But after the elections Bhartiya Janta Party and Bahujan Samaj Party formed a coalition government under the leadership of Ms. Mayawati.

- **POPULISTIC POLITICS:** In India, the political parties adopt populist politics to come to power. The leaders exploit the compulsions of the people by raising populist slogans. For example, in 1971 Congress Party raised the slogan of 'Garibi Hatao' and again in 1975; it tried to get the support of the people on the basis of 20 point programme. b) During the Lok Sabha elections of 1977, Janta Party raised the slogan of 'Democracy V/s Dictatorship' whereas Congress Party raised the slogan of 'Stability V/s Anarchy. c) Similarly during the Lok Sabha elections of 1991, Congress Party raised the slogan of 'Stability and Development', Bhartiya Janta Party of 'Ram, Roti and Naya' and Janta Dal of 'Social Justice'. Though there was no special wave in favour of any political party but to gain some recognition.
- **GROWING INFLUENCE OF MONEY POWER ON POLITICS:** The politics in India is also not free from the influence of money power in India, the rich people have their strong hold on politics. b) During elections they help the political parties with money and after the elections they encash the benefits also. Though the Election Commission has fixed the upper limit of the money to be spent during elections, yet in reality the money spent is many times more than the prescribed limit and the major portion of this comes from black money and black money breeds politics. c) Today, through fair or foul means, the politicians try to amass as much money as possible, therefore, the role of politicians in major scams cannot be ruled out. They get nominations with the use of money power and after getting nominations, they have to spend crores in order to win the election. After winning the election, they again have to please their party bosses in order to become ministers etc. After getting appointed on high offices, the politicians try to collect as much money as possible for the next elections. This way, their public service becomes self service. So, the politics needs to be freed from the evil influence of money power.
- **CHALLENGES TO DEMOCRACY:** Challenges to democracy in India are also significant. Issues such as political violence, threats to freedom of expression, and the suppression of dissent are increasingly prevalent. The rise of authoritarian tendencies within the political framework poses risks to the democratic fabric of the nation. Civil society organizations and activists play a crucial role in advocating for democratic values and resisting these trends, emphasizing the importance of accountability and transparency. Efforts to contain and suppress Covid-19 'led to a further erosion of civil liberties'.
In summary, the trends in Indian politics reflect a dynamic and evolving landscape. The centralization of power, the rise of identity politics, the influence of technology, corporate interests, and challenges to democracy all play crucial roles in shaping the future of Indian politics. As the country navigates these complexities, the resilience of its democratic institutions and the active participation of its citizens will be vital in ensuring a balanced and inclusive political environment. The political landscape in India is characterized by a complex interplay of various factors, including ideology, regionalism, and the influence of globalization. Over the past few years, several key trends have emerged that shape the current political environment. In the words of Mahatma Gandhi, "Politics without principle is the devil's game".